

A Short Story: The Lone Wolf [B2]

La storia di Wendy non è per nulla convenzionale: rimasta orfana da bambina, è stata cresciuta da un branco di lupi. Da allora, qualcosa in lei continua a riportarla verso quel mondo.

Another bunch of flowers from Mattie,” said Rita, entering Wendy’s office. “Whatever he did, he’s obviously trying hard to apologise.” “He needs to try a bit harder than this,” said Wendy, accepting the flowers and then tossing them aside. Wendy hadn’t told Rita, the secretary at the university where she was teaching a course on wolf behaviour, what Mattie had done. She hadn’t told anyone what he’d done. It was too terrible to confide in anyone. And besides she had nobody to confide in — no close family, no real friends. She had considered Mattie her family, Mattie and her beloved dog, AJ. But she’d lost them both on the same day, what she now considered to be the worst day of her life, or at least the worst day she could remember. Perhaps the worst day of all had been the day her father died. She’d been only three years old at the time, riding on her father’s back in a child carrier as he’d hiked a trail in the Gila National Forest in New Mexico. This wasn’t unusual. Her father loved hiking, and, as many people had told her, he loved her more than anything. A single father, he had always taken her with him when hiking, always stayed on the trails, and always had an abundance of food and water. But that day, something had gone terribly wrong. Medical experts later concluded that her father had had a stroke that had caused him to become disorientated and wander off the trail. He had collapsed and died, and she, Wendy, had wandered off alone, only to be adopted by a pack of wolves. A hiker had discovered her over a month later, safe in a wolves’ den. Wolf biologists were still debating why the wolves had adopted her and how they had protected her from the elements and kept her alive. Now a wolf biologist herself, Wendy too had studied the pack that had adopted her. She had been returning to Gila National Forest since childhood to observe them and document their behavior, as well as their interactions with her. It was obvious that they recognised her scent and still considered her one of them. And she too considered herself one of them to a certain extent. After she’d been rescued, she’d been adopted by a family of nature enthusiasts

who'd supported her interest in wolves and tried to help her adapt to a life without her father. But she'd always felt alienated from them, and from everyone around her. She knew her father's death, and her time with the wolves, had had a profound impact on her. Fiction

A Short Story: In Philpot Lane A Londra, una piccola statua di due topolini che mangiano del formaggio onora la memoria di due operai che trasformarono un'antipatia personale in una tragedia. Rachel Roberts, Rachel Roberts She had forced herself to be more sociable over time, but she'd always felt more in harmony with wolves than with humans. Their social structure was complex but also simple, based on a rigid hierarchy. And they were extremely loyal to their [packs](#), which were in effect their families. When she'd met Mattie, Wendy had thought she'd finally found the person who would become her future family — her husband and the father of her children. But then came that terrible day, when her beloved dog, AJ, had died, just as suddenly and unexpectedly as her father had. Devastated, Wendy had gone to see Mattie, who was at home studying for the [bar examination](#) — his final step to becoming a [qualified lawyer](#). But when she'd arrived at his home, she'd found him in bed with another woman. That was two months ago, and he'd been imploring her to forgive him ever since, promising that it had been the only time he'd been unfaithful to her, that the woman, another law student, had come to his home to study but then seduced him, that he loved Wendy more than anything and would do anything to be with her again. "Okay," she told him on the phone now, making a decision. "If you want to be with me, then be a part of my world." She'd made a considerable effort to be a part of his world, by going to [social occasions](#) with other law students and professors, events she found insufferable. Now it was his turn. "I'm going to Gila National Forest for a month this winter, and you're coming with me." It was on their third night in Gila National Forest that Wendy woke to the sound of [howling](#). She left the [tent](#) and howled in return, imitating the sound of the wolf [pack](#) that had once saved her life. "What's going on?" asked Mattie, waking to the sound of her [howling](#). He looked terrible, [deprived](#) for the first time of the comforts of modern civilization. "Are you ready to meet my first adoptive family?" said Wendy. "Maybe you can learn something from them about loyalty. They would never [betray](#) one another the way you [betrayed](#) me." She collected her camping and hunting

equipment, everything she would need to survive in nature, perhaps indefinitely. “What? Where are going? You can’t just leave me.” But Wendy was intent on doing just that, leaving Mattie and the human world, at least for a while. “Now you know what it feels like to be betrayed,” she said. “I hope you can find your way back to the trail before they find you. It’s winter and they’re hungry.” At that, she walked into the forest and towards the destiny that was set for her the day her father had died — to become the most famous wolf biologist the world had ever known. This time she wouldn’t just observe the wolves; she would become one of them, no longer a lone wolf, but part of the only family to which she truly belonged.

Glossary

- **confide in** = fidarsi di
- **scent** = odore
- **tent** = tenda
- **belonged** = appartenere
- **bunch of flowers** = mazzo di fiori
- **tossing them aside** = mettere da parte
- **hiked** = fare trekking
- **trail** = sentiero
- **wander off** = allontanarsi
- **to a certain extent** = in un certo senso
- **bar examination** = esame di abilitazione forense
- **qualified lawyer** = avvocato abilitato
- **riding on her father's back** = a cavalcioni sulle spalle di suo padre
- **stroke** = ictus
- **pack** = branco
- **den** = tana
- **social occasions** = eventi mondani
- **howling** = ululato
- **deprived** = privato
- **betray** = tradire
- **apologise** = scusarsi
- **intent on** = decisa a